after which it began to rise sharply. Notably, genome sequencing of several samples at the time from Punjab, Haryana and Delhi were attributable to the Alpha variant (B.1.1.7 strain) which originated in the UK.[18] One must also keep in mind that the second wave didn't really begin when the number of cases started rising, but rather when the preceding, declining trend of the curve of the first wave ended. A closer look at district-wise data of areas where most of the protesting farmers came from in Punjab and Haryana shows similar declining trends from the first week of January 2021. On further observing curves on a graph plotting case numbers in various states, it becomes amply evident that the rise in cases began in Punjab and Haryana weeks before it began in Maharashtra, which is popularly believed to be the state which started the second wave of COVID-19 infections in India.[19]

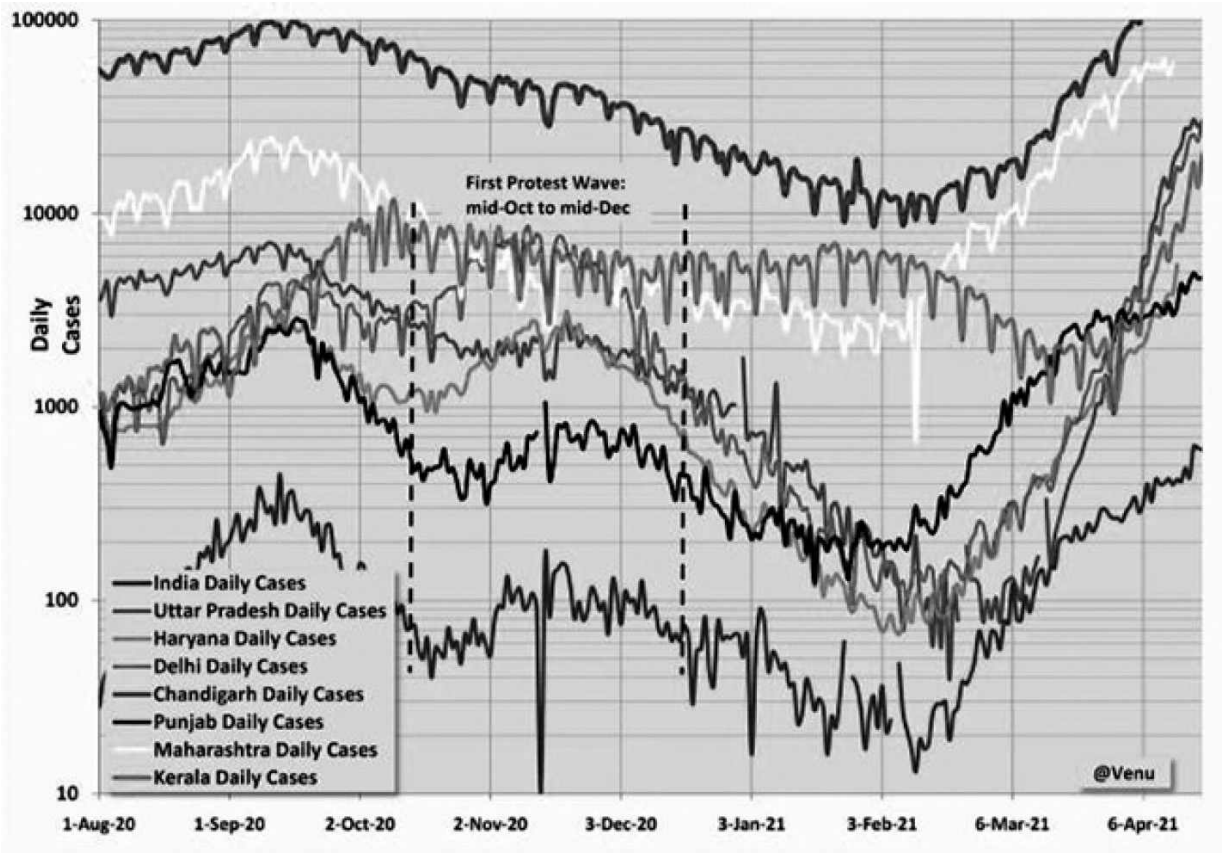


Figure 15.1: India: Wuhan Epidemic Data

Source: Venu Gopal Narayanan, 'Data Story: Did the "Farmers' Protest" Cause the Second Wave of Covid-19 in India?' *Swarajya*, 11 May 2021.